EDITION	FOR	FORMAT	READ TIME
2026	HOME SERVICES	PRINT + INTERACTIVE	15 MIN

GOOGLE BUSINESS PROFILE · AUDIT CHECKLIST

The GBP Checklist that finds missed calls.

Thirty-nine checks across seven sections. Tick what's done. Circle what isn't. Fix the circled ones first — and stop bleeding leads to the contractor two miles away.

SECTIONS	CHECKS	PAGES	PRICETAG
07	39	10	Free

Tick what's done. Fix the circled ones first.

Your Google Business Profile is the storefront for every "plumber near me" search in your service area. A weak one quietly costs you calls every week — usually to a competitor whose work isn't even better than yours.

This is a working checklist, not a blog post. Run it once to get a baseline. Run it once a quarter to keep it tight. The 44 items below are everything we audit when we run a Local Visibility Audit ourselves.

LEGEND

- ☐ Not done — start here
- ☑ Complete

HOW TO SCORE

Tally checked boxes at the end.

See p. 09 for what your score means.

INTERACTIVE

Boxes are clickable on screen and saved to this device. Print clean, or save as PDF.

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§ 01 Profile Foundation — 9 checks
§ 02 Services — 4 checks
§ 03 Photos — 7 checks
§ 04 Reviews — 5 checks
§ 05 Google Posts — 4 checks
§ 06 Overlooked Features — 5 checks
§ 07 Security & Suspension Prep — 5 checks
§ 08 Score & Next Steps — Verdict

PROFILE FOUNDATION

01/07 Get these wrong and nothing else matters.

The basics Google ranks you on before anything fancy gets a chance.

- [ ] **Business name matches exactly.**
  Same spelling, same punctuation as your legal or DBA name. No added keywords ("Best Plumber NWA"). Google will suspend you for it.
- [ ] **Primary category is as specific as possible.**
  "HVAC Contractor" beats "Contractor." Look up what your top competitor uses, then pick the most accurate option that also fits your main service.
- [ ] **Secondary categories are set.**
  Add up to 9. If you do HVAC and plumbing, both should be listed.
- [ ] **Business description is filled out (750 chars).**
  Lead with what you do and where. Include your top 2–3 services naturally. No keyword stuffing. Write it like you're explaining yourself to a neighbor.
- [ ] **Address is handled correctly.**
  If customers don't come to your location, hide the address and set yourself as a Service Area Business (SAB). Showing a home address you don't want public is a common suspension trigger.
- [ ] **Service area is a realistic territory.**
  Stay within roughly a 2-hour radius of your base. Going wider dilutes your ranking for every city in the zone.
- [ ] **Phone number is correct and consistent.**
  Same format, same number as your website and every other listing.
- [ ] **Website URL is correct.**
  Check it. Broken links are surprisingly common after site redesigns.
- [ ] **Hours are accurate, including holidays.**
  Incorrect hours are one of the top reasons customers leave a negative review before even calling.

> FIELD NOTE
> Suspensions almost always trace back to this page. If you fix only one section, fix this one.

SERVICES

02/07 Your service list is a keyword list.

Treat it that way.

- [ ] **Individual services are listed, not just categories.**
  Don't just pick "Plumbing." Add "Emergency Water Heater Repair," "Drain Cleaning," "Sump Pump Installation," etc.
- [ ] **Service names match how customers search.**
  Think about what someone types at 11pm when something breaks. That's your service name.
- [ ] **Service descriptions are filled in.**
  Each service has a description field. Use it. 1–3 sentences describing the problem you solve. This feeds AI Overviews and voice search results.
- [ ] **Service prices are filled in (optional but worth it).**
  Even a range ("Starting at $89") builds trust and filters out price-shoppers who would've wasted your time anyway.

PHOTOS

03/07 Google's AI reads your photos.

Customers judge you by them.

- [ ] **Cover photo is a high-quality job-site or truck photo.**
  Not a logo. Not a stock image. Something real.
- [ ] **Logo is uploaded.**
  Clean version on a transparent or brand-colored background.
- [ ] **At least 10 photos are live on the profile.**
  Bare profiles rank lower. Period.
- [ ] **Photos are added weekly (1–5 per week).**
  Profiles with regularly updated photos get 42% more direction requests. Set a phone reminder if you have to.

REVIEWS

04/07 The top 3 Map Pack results average 240 reviews.

This is the long game. Start it today.

- [ ] **You have a review request process.**
  QR code on an invoice. Text after job completion. Follow-up email. If you're not asking, you're not getting.
- [ ] **You're responding to every review.**
  Every one. The 5-stars and the 1-stars.
- [ ] **Your responses include the service + city.**
  Naturally. "Glad we could get your AC sorted before the Fayetteville heat hits" is doing SEO work. Google indexes your replies.
- [ ] **Negative reviews are answered within 24 hours.**
  Calm, professional, specific. Never defensive. Future customers read how you handle conflict more than they read the complaint itself.
- [ ] **You're using the 5-step reply formula.**
  01 Personalize — use their name.
  02 Highlight the specific job.
  03 Include service + city naturally.
  04 Reference a value (speed, cleanliness, honesty).
  05 Soft CTA — "Call us when that water heater starts making noise."

> WHY THIS MATTERS
> Reviews are the single biggest variable separating you from the contractor ranking above you. They are also the cheapest one to fix — you just have to ask.

GOOGLE POSTS

05/07 Treat it like a mini-blog.

Most contractors ignore this entirely. That's the opportunity.

- [ ] **You're posting at least once per week.**
  A short post (80–100 words) is enough. Problem → what you did → result. Keep it plain.
- [ ] **Posts have a CTA button set.**
  "Call Now" is the default choice for home services. Use it.
- [ ] **URLs go in the "Learn More" button field, not the post body.**
  Links in the post body don't render as clickable. Common mistake.
- [ ] **Posts reference a specific service and city.**
  "We replaced a failed pressure tank for a homeowner in Bentonville this week" beats "We do water well services."

OVERLOOKED FEATURES

06/07 What most contractors leave on the table.

Five quiet wins your competitors haven't bothered with.

- [ ] **Q&A section is seeded.**
  You can post your own questions and answer them. "Do you offer same-day service?" → "Yes, we offer same-day service for most HVAC calls in the Rogers/Bentonville area." These show up in your profile and feed voice search.
- [ ] **WhatsApp is connected (if you use it).**
  Lets customers message you instantly for emergencies. Fast response wins the job.
- [ ] **Social profiles are linked.**
  Connecting active TikTok or Instagram accounts contributes to what Google considers "digital authority."
- [ ] **Products section is used (if applicable).**
  Some contractors use this to showcase equipment brands or featured service packages. Worth testing.

ACCOUNT SECURITY & SUSPENSION PREP

07/07

Google suspends without warning. You get one appeal.

Be ready before you need to be.

- [ ] **Profile ownership is confirmed.**
  You — the actual owner — have manager or owner access. Not just an employee or an old agency account.
- [ ] **Two-factor authentication is on.**
  Suspended profiles can't be recovered if you lose account access.
- [ ] **"Survival Folder" exists and is current.**
  Keep copies of: LLC or DBA registration, a utility bill or lease at your business address, and trade licenses. You'll need these for any reinstatement appeal.
- [ ] **Verification video is ready.**
  Short clip showing your branded truck, tools, and uniform. Record it now so you have it if Google asks.
- [ ] **No violations are present.**
  Review Google's guidelines for SABs specifically. Common traps: keyword stuffing in the business name, multiple listings for the same business, virtual office addresses.

> WORST-CASE PLANNING
>
> A suspended profile feels like the sky is falling. With the survival folder ready, it's a 48-hour problem. Without it, it can be permanent.

Add up your checks. Find your verdict below.

Thirty-nine checks total. Be honest — circle the ones you're not sure about and treat them as "no." Where you land tells you what to fix first.

RANGE · 35–39

35+

Strong shape

You're tight. Now it's a habits game: weekly photos, weekly post, ongoing review requests. Keep the streak going.

RANGE · 20–34

20–34

Real gaps

The basics are mostly there but there are leaks hurting your ranking right now. Prioritize Section 01 and Section 04 first.

RANGE · < 20

< 20

Working against you

Your profile is actively losing you calls. Start with Section 01 — Foundation — before anything else. Don't pass go.

WANT TO KNOW EXACTLY WHERE YOU STAND?

Free Local Visibility Audit for NWA contractors.

No pitch, no pressure. We'll show you what's missing on your profile and what it's costing you in calls each week.

BOOK A FREE AUDIT

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